Automatic Child Support Intermediation in France

Data and Empirical Strategy

Public Economics – Research Proposal

ENSAE – Institut Polytechnique de Paris

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Data: Source, Coverage, and Sample

Dimension	Proposed data and sample
Data source	ALLSTAT-FR6, administrative records on beneficiaries of the French Family Allowance Funds (CAF), produced by CNAF and available for research through CASD authorization.
Geographical coverage	France; main analysis restricted to metropolitan France to ensure consistent geographical coverage.
Study period	2017–2025, covering several years before and after the 2022–2023 IFPA reform.
Unit of observation	CAF beneficiary case $\times$ month, with longitudinal tracking of households where identifiers permit.
Target population	Single-parent beneficiary households with dependent children, focusing on families with identifiable child support arrangements.
Sample construction	Identify single-parent households, construct monthly trajectories, and distinguish recorded child support obligations from missing information.
Data access	ALLSTAT-FR6 is documented in the CASD catalogue;

Data: Sample Construction and Observation Unit

1. **Identify the study population.** Select single-parent CAF households with dependent children using `SITFAM` (family status), `PRESCONJ` (partner presence) and `NBENLEFA` (dependent children).
2. **Construct longitudinal observations.** Use reference dates and anonymised identifiers (`DTREFFRE`, `IDANORES`) to assess whether households can be followed across periods. Check changes in beneficiary status and CAF transfers.
3. **Identify child support arrangements.** Use `TPA` (child support indicator), `MTPADU` (amount due) and `MTALIMFO` (amount received by the household). Distinguish zero amounts from missing values.
4. **Characterise family transitions.** Use `NBMSIFAM` (months since the last change in family status) to approximate recent changes, without interpreting them automatically as separations.
5. **Assess treatment identification.** Investigate `NATJUG` (nature of the judicial decision concerning a defaulting child support debtor) and the availability of enforceable-order dates before defining reform-exposure cohorts.

Proposed observation unit

One CAF beneficiary case at each available reference date, with child support information, family characteristics, social benefits and reported resources.

Data: Measuring Child Support

Variable	Dictionary description	Potential use
MTPADU	Amount of child support due	Measure of recorded child support obligations.
MTALIMFO	Child support received by the household	Candidate outcome: child support receipts.
MTALIMME	Child support received by the woman	Gender-specific measure of receipts.
MTALIMVE	Child support paid by the household	Potential measure of outgoing child support.
MTPALIFT	Quarterly child support received by the household	Alternative measure of receipts over a quarterly reference period.
TPA	Child support indicator	Identification of households with recorded child support information.
NBDEBPEN	Number of debtors associated with ASF	Potential information on child support debtors in the ASF system.

Measurement issue

Data: Policy Exposure and Measurement Challenges

Institutional variation

March 2022: automatic intermediation for newly fixed child support in judicial divorce proceedings. **January 2023:** extension to other relevant enforceable titles. Existing orders are not automatically equivalent to new orders under these rules.

Needed for causal design	Status in ALLSTAT
Exact order date	Not established; first observed pension is *not* necessarily a newly issued order.
Type of enforceable title	`NATJUG` may help, but meaning and coverage require checking.
Actual IFPA enrollment	No confirmed direct indicator in currently reviewed variables.
Actual monthly payments	Must establish whether recorded pension amounts measure payments or declarations.

Main distinction: policy eligibility, actual IFPA participation and observed child support receipts are not interchangeable.

Methodology: Source of Identification

Methodology: Equation and Estimand

Methodology: Assumptions, Threats, and Feasibility

References and Data Documentation

- **CASD:** ALLSTAT-FR6, *Fichier statistique des allocataires des CAF – données définitives*. `https://www.casd.eu/source/fichier-statistique-des-allocataires-des-caf-donnees-definitives/`
- **CNAF (2024):** *Évaluation du dispositif d'intermédiation financière des pensions alimentaires en phase de généralisation*, Dossier d'étude no. 233.
- **CNAF / DREES (2025):** statistical analysis of the November 2022 ASF revaluation (ALLSTAT-FR6).
- **Rubolino, E.:** *Outlining Data and Methodology*, Public Economics, ENSAE–IP Paris (course slides).

Status

Proposed research design based on public data documentation; no access to individual ALLSTAT records or validated causal sample is claimed.